

machine. When we say the files were “frozen”, it actually means that it was made sure that those files weren’t altered. Later on, you can use the feature in the virtualization software you’re using to revert back to that snapshot.

When you revert back to a snapshot you took earlier, you get the machine as it was when you took the snapshot. If you had a file on the guest operating system when you took that snapshot, but deleted it after taking the snapshot, the file would be restored. The settings would be as you left them and the virtual machine would behave as if it was never changed at all. This is because the virtual hard disk files were frozen when the snapshot was taken.

NOTE

Don’t confuse this feature with “cloning” which actually creates a new virtual machine with the same state as the virtual machine you’re cloning from. When you “clone” a virtual machine, you actually create a new virtual machine which may (depending on the features of the virtualization software in use) use the same disk files and configuration of the present machine or have its own set of disk and configuration files which make it behave just as the virtual machine you’re cloning. It may be a clone of only a particular “state” (we’re talking about the state determined by the “snapshots” you’ve taken for the machine) or have all the states. The difference between snapshot and cloning is that cloning creates a new virtual machine with possibly new virtual hard disks and configurations while snapshots just freeze the current machine and create new files to store the changes you’re going to make to the current machine. You might think that cloning too is just like taking a snapshot – after all, you can create multiple clones of the same machine at the times you want; but that’s not the truth. There are two main differences. First, a clone will take up more space on your computer because the disk files are recreated or copied. Secondly, you can’t create a clone of a virtual machine while that machine is running. Although cloning is a feature, there’s a reason we don’t mention it as a feature you should look for in virtualization software. To create a new virtual machine in the current state, you simply need to copy its virtual hard disk files (and possibly some configuration files which are created in the same folder / directory as the virtual hard disk), paste it somewhere else and create a new virtual machine utilising those files. There, you now have a clone! You can then remove the snapshots in the copied machine to make it come to whatever state you want it to.